

Antarctica

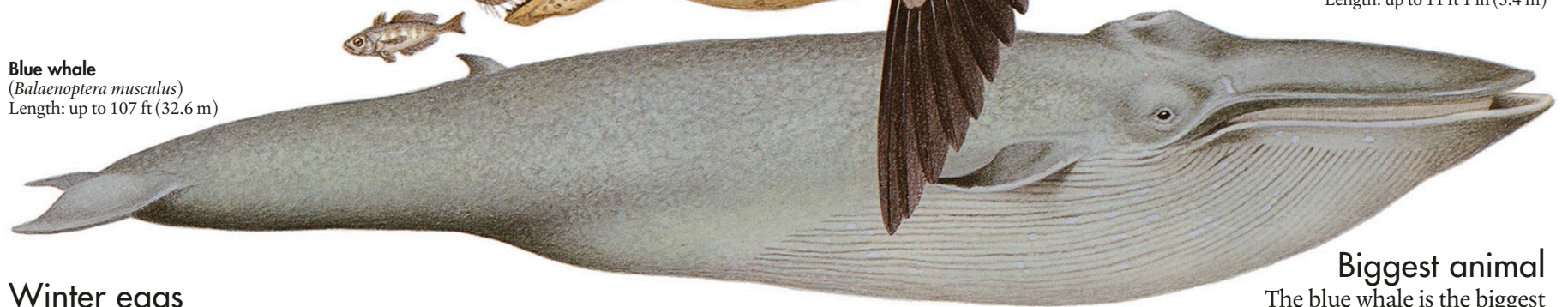


ANTARCTICA IS THE WORLD'S coldest and most isolated continent. The average temperature at the South Pole is -56°F (-49°C). In the winter months, it is dark all the time and temperatures as low as -128.6°F (-89.2°C) have been recorded. Antarctica is also one of the windiest places on Earth—the wind speed can reach 200 mph (322 kph). A permanent cap of ice covers most of the continent. In some places, this ice is over 2.5 miles (4 km) thick. In these harsh conditions only a few tiny insects and spiders manage to survive on the land, but the seas are rich in food and support huge numbers of animals.

Swift hunter

The leopard seal lives around the edge of the pack ice. It can swim very fast to catch the smaller seals, penguins, fish, and krill on which it feeds. It can even swallow even large prey whole.

Blue whale
(*Balaenoptera musculus*)
Length: up to 107 ft (32.6 m)



Wandering albatross
(*Diomedea exulans*)
Wingspan: up to 11 ft 6 in (3.5 m)

Largest wingspan

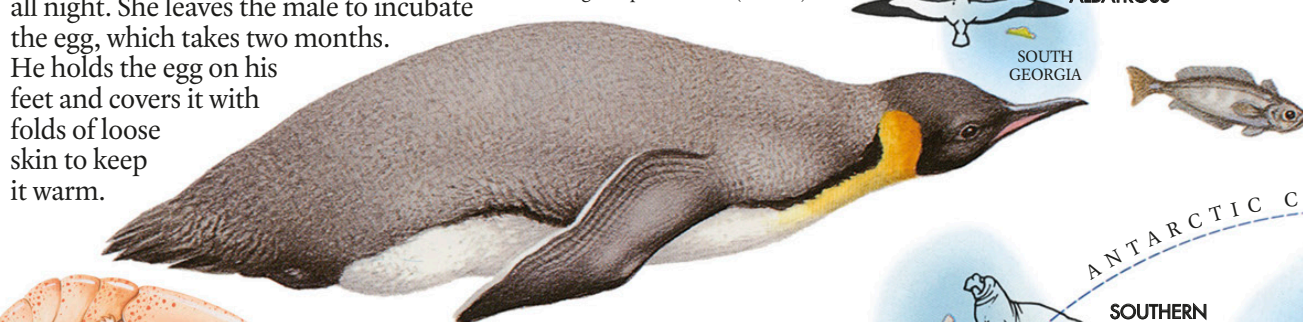
The wandering albatross has the largest wingspan of any bird on Earth. Its long wings help it glide over the seas for hours on end. It nests on isolated islands in the southern oceans, where it is safe from enemies. The albatross can live for up to 40 years.

Leopard seal
(*Hydrurga leptonyx*)
Length: up to 11 ft 1 in (3.4 m)

Winter eggs

The female emperor penguin lays one egg in the winter, when it is dark all day and all night. She leaves the male to incubate the egg, which takes two months. He holds the egg on his feet and covers it with folds of loose skin to keep it warm.

Emperor penguin
(*Aptenodytes forsteri*)
Height: up to 3 ft 9 in (1.15 m)



WANDERING ALBATROSS

SOUTH GEORGIA

Biggest animal

The blue whale is the biggest animal ever to have lived on Earth. It is 20 times heavier than the largest land animal, the African elephant. The blue whale eats krill, which it sieves from the water with plates in its mouth.



Antarctic krill
(*Euphausia superba*)
Length: up to 2.5 in (6.5 cm)

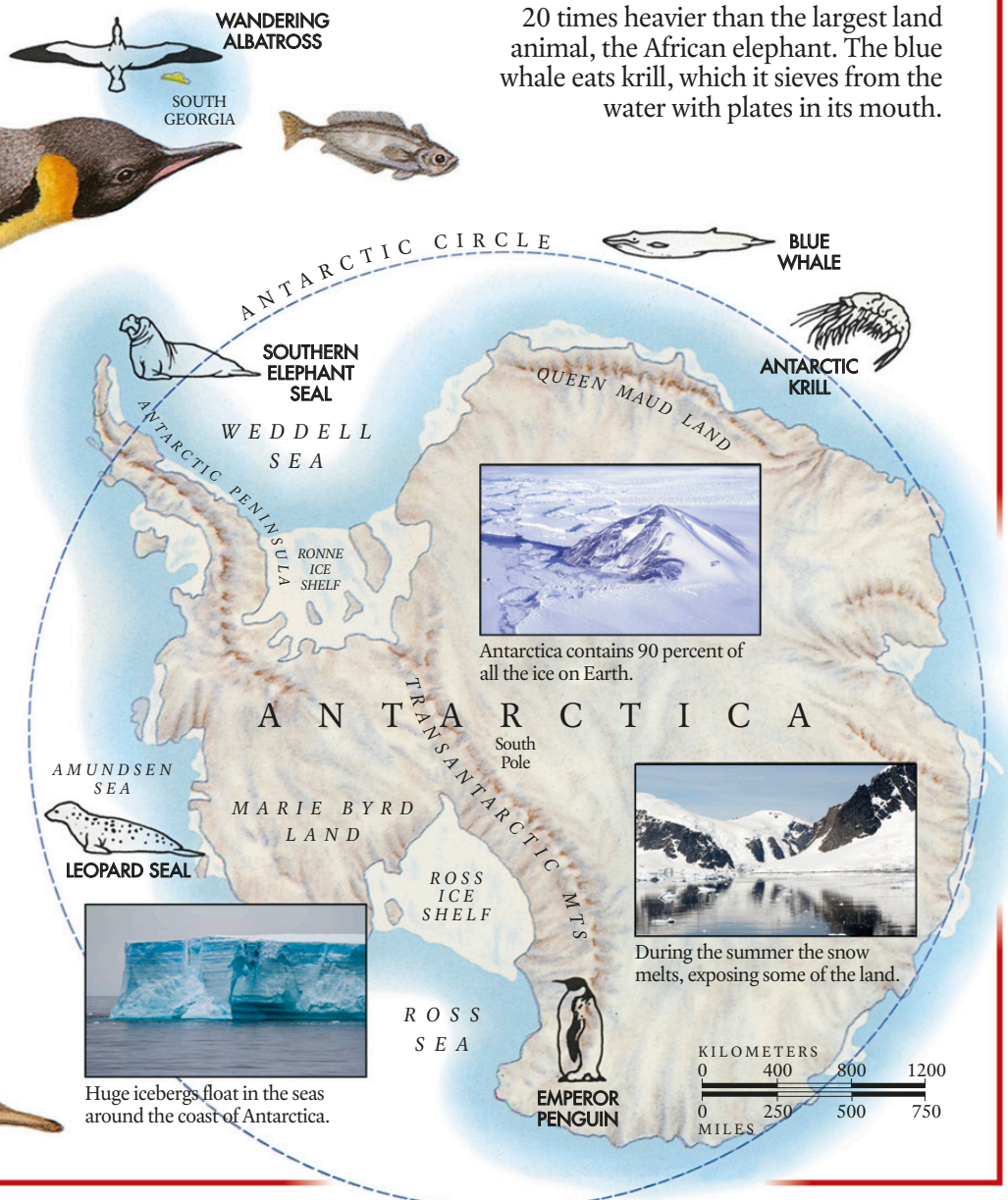
Feathery filter

Krill are shrimp-like animals. They feed on microscopic plants, which they filter out of the water with their feathery front legs.

Heavyweight seal

The elephant seal is the largest of all seals. A big male can weigh up to 8,800 lb (4,000 kg). In the mating season, the male guards a group of females and roars challenges to rival males through the inflatable bag of skin on his nose, which acts as a loudspeaker.

Southern elephant seal
(*Mirounga leonina*)
Length: up to 16 ft 5 in (5 m)



Antarctica contains 90 percent of all the ice on Earth.

Huge icebergs float in the seas around the coast of Antarctica.

During the summer the snow melts, exposing some of the land.